

**Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action
2024 Candidate Questionnaire**

Candidate Name: Terry Taplin

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council, District 2

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels. The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including citywide zoning for "missing middle" housing, a San Pablo Specific Plan, an updated Demolition Ordinance, and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

I view these as critical measures required to redress Berkeley's historic wrongs and the adverse impacts of exclusionary zoning, downzoning, and other erroneous restrictive housing policies aimed at reducing the ability of young people, marginalized communities, and working professionals to find homes in Berkeley. Corridor zoning and middle housing are the most critical programs for the city to implement.

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

a. Missing Middle housing

Middle Housing is a major priority of mine. Many of the neighborhoods in my district, including my home neighborhood, have a mix of middle housing typologies. I support strong middle housing policies that maximize existing envelopes, streamline production, protect tenants, and incentivize onsite BMR units.

b. San Pablo specific plan

I support a San Pablo plan that achieves fair housing parity consistent with all of the city's commercial corridors, emphasizing commercial mixed-use, revised nodes, and support for small businesses and arts/cultural organizations. San Pablo Ave must also be made safe for multi-modal transport, including bus and transit improvements, safe crossing infrastructure, and bicycle facilities in an integrated regional network along the corridor.

c. Zoning for housing in high-resource neighborhoods like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave

I view this as imperative to meet our fair housing obligations. This is a key housing justice priority of mine.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas- powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings.

Upcoming policy initiatives include the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program, Measure GG, the Bay Area Air Quality Management District's regional ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, and more.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around how Berkeley can reduce emissions from transportation and buildings, and how we should align the climate transition with our other goals as a city.

My top priority is the reduction of transportation emissions. Funding, prioritizing, and supporting staff in implementing the Bicycle and Pedestrian Plans and Electric Mobility Roadmap are critical. During my first term, I negotiated \$32M in community benefits through the Bayer Development Agreement, which created funding to support programs that increased access to e-bikes and other micro-mobility options for low-income households and residents of color. I also passed the 51B University-Shattuck Mobility Improvements referral to advance transit, pedestrian, and bicycle, infrastructure along the city's central bus route connecting the Marina to the Downtown. The Bayer community benefits package also created funding streams for green renovation programs and supported organizations that partner with community members in this work.

Measure GG, however, falls short of the just transition by failing to invest in the utility infrastructure requisite to move the city's largest producers and employers off of fossil fuels while adversely affecting beloved community institutions. Measure GG would wreck the economy of West Berkeley and the revenue producers that many of our city-wide programs rely on for sustenance.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I was very proud to support and champion the adoption of our Housing Element. The Element represents a culmination of years of advocacy led by our pro-housing community and our hard-fought pro-housing council majority. The Element codified a course of action that will redress our racial and economic exclusion legacy over the next several years and help the city truly become the climate leader we consider ourselves to be.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

The Housing Element. As an urban center of a major economic region, the city must build housing close to jobs and transit to reduce sprawl and curb super-commutes. As someone whose entire life has been marked by the climate crisis and housing precarity, I do not have the luxury of kicking the can down the road or avoiding difficult decisions. I was proud to vote for the Housing Element as I have been proud to cast every pro-housing vote that has come before the dais.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley. How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new Homes?

I am committed to ACTC's San Pablo Multimodal Corridor Project, adding electric ferry service to the Berkeley Marina Pier, advancing the Bicycle and Pedestrian Plans, and authoring the 51B University-Shattuck Mobility Improvements item, which is ranked within the top 10 of the council's ranked priorities.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent. Of the two competing street paving measures on the ballot this November, one of the major differences between the two is the approach to funding safety improvements for walking and biking. Measure EE would provide safety funding only for traffic calming on bicycle boulevards and major pedestrian projects identified in the Pedestrian Plan. Measure FF would provide funding to implement safety measures throughout the city, based on existing plans. What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets? What is your perspective on these two measures?

All road improvements must include treatments and facilities to increase safety for pedestrians, cyclists, other micro-mobility commuters, and persons with disabilities. Safety must be our highest priority, and mobility is the best use of our road infrastructure. I strongly support Measure FF and am carrying its lit in the field.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today. Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

I support using onsite inclusionary and in-lieu options as long as projects remain financially feasible and do not reduce the number of units built.

8. Many of the highest income neighborhoods in Berkeley are also in the Hillside Overlay, portions of which are in the California Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone (CalFire VHFHSZ). How should we balance fire risk with affirmatively furthering fair housing?

The city must take the necessary steps to truly mitigate fire risk instead of cleaving to an untenable status quo. The city must enforce red-curb-ing and remove parking along evacuation routes to clear egress and ingress and enable the transport of emergency vehicles. Portions of the Hillside Overlay (Northside, Frat Row, etc.) have existing multifamily residences. As Chair of the Public Safety Committee, I am committed to balancing fire risk and fair housing by carefully evaluating the upcoming evacuation study and Local Hazard Mitigation Plan Update.